

NEGOTIATION MGT 420 Weekend Intensive

Spring 2026

Professor:

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Office Hours: by appointment

Schedule: Friday: 9AM – 5PM
Saturday: 9AM – 5PM
Sunday: 9AM – 5PM

COURSE DESCRIPTION

Whether you're asking for a higher salary from your boss, working on a better price for a used car, choosing a movie to watch with your partner, arguing with your roommate over who should do the dishes, or calling your politicians to demand a ceasefire, every day you are negotiating for something. Although negotiations are a ubiquitous part of our professional, personal, and civic lives, many people know little about the strategy and psychology of effective negotiations. Why do we sometimes get our way, while other times we walk away feeling frustrated by our inability to achieve the agreement we desire? How can we better achieve our goals, build and maintain strong relationships with others, and optimize mutual gains?

Negotiation is the art and science of securing agreements between two or more parties who are seeking to maximize their outcomes and who can ideally improve their outcomes by working together. This course develops your negotiation skills by taking you through a series of simulations and debriefings that reveal the influence of various strategies, tactics, and processes in a wide range of contexts. Each simulation highlights essential concepts that explain performance in negotiation. The course addresses common problems that managers and professionals face during negotiations, and it is designed to complement the technical and diagnostic skills learned in other courses in your curriculum.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

First, you should acquire the conceptual skills necessary to become a sophisticated analyst of negotiation situations. Second you should learn a great deal about yourself from repeated exposure to negotiation situations. Third, you should gain an understanding of the psychological processes and biases that underlie the judgment of negotiators. Fourth, you should be able to use this knowledge to secure greater yield in negotiations. The bottom-line: you should come out of this course as an analytically and intuitively savvy negotiator.

FORMAT

Students will negotiate in pairs or larger groups at the beginning of class. After that, we will debrief through class discussion of the simulation. The course will build cumulatively from (seemingly) simple negotiations to those of greater complexity. Structured negotiation exercises are used to isolate and emphasize specific analytic points and essential skills.

The beginning of the course will focus on **Value Claiming**. These are situations in which each party attempts to enlarge his or her share of what is taken to be a fixed pie. In this unit, we introduce basic concepts and tactics, with a special emphasis on cognitive biases in negotiation. The middle of the course will focus on **Value Creation**. These sessions will explore negotiations that contain elements of both cooperation and competition; that is, cases where the parties can “enlarge the pie” by creating joint gains. We identify the potential sources of gains – and why they are often not fully captured, with a special emphasis on the role of perspective taking, communication skills, and trust. We also analyze the tension between cooperative moves to create value and competitive moves to claim it. This tension is fundamental to negotiation and affects virtually all tactical and strategic choices. The end of the course will focus on **Multiparty Negotiation**. Here, we explore how the dynamics of these negotiations differ from two party settings. In particular, we examine the strategic and tactical issues that are essential to any sophisticated building (or destroying) of coalitions.

NEGOTIATION EXERCISES

You will take part in a series of negotiation exercises. For each case, you will be assigned a particular role, and you will be given background materials, instructions, and (often) confidential information to aid you in your preparation. You will be paired with one or more negotiating partners. Typically, you will spend the first part of each class negotiating these cases. The second part of each class will be spent on debriefing and analysis. The negotiation exercises are the single most important vehicle for learning in the course.

Some people may feel uncomfortable negotiating with other class members. Previous students, however, have overwhelmingly found the experience rewarding, particularly the low cost opportunity to “try on” different negotiating approaches. Such experimentation is encouraged as long as it is undertaken seriously. To the extent that your wits and emotions are engaged, the experience promises to help you become a more aware and effective negotiator.

Our discussion will often focus on how different strategic choices (and interpersonal skills) drive relative success at the bargaining table. The cases do not involve real money or actual issues, of course, but past students have relished the opportunity to test their effectiveness and to try new techniques they learn in the course. Because everyone will be negotiating the same case, which will then be extensively discussed, you will get a chance to see something that is seldom visible when you negotiate, i.e., how well you might have done had you negotiated differently.

We will record everyone's results so you can compare the outcome that you negotiated with the results obtained by other people in your same role. **These tracked results are not factored in course grades:** they are meant only to facilitate group discussion and give you a sense of your performance in different negotiation settings. Your faithful and creative preparation and participation are part of your grade, as are the quality of the insights that you draw from the negotiating experience. Failure to prepare for and carry out an exercise would not only adversely affect your own learning, but would deny valuable experience for fellow students with whom you're paired. Thus, your actual presence and conscientious preparation is a primary requisite of this course.

Naturally, even when you are negotiating with someone you know and like, do not simply give in to him or her. Doing so would produce a poorer result for you and would deprive them of a legitimate test of their skills. As with a tennis match among friends, playing vigorously and intelligently does more for everyone's game, and is much more fun.

Confidential instructions

You will receive confidential instructions in many of the exercises. **Do not show your instructions to others.** You may choose to reveal or discuss some of the contents of your confidential information – indeed this kind of communication is often indispensable “at-the-table.” However, you must not physically show your actual confidential instruction sheets. This rule is intended to mirror reality: in most actual situations, you cannot simply show the full set of your underlying interests and information to your negotiating counterparts.

The instructions for the exercises are designed to be self-explanatory. Please follow them carefully. Otherwise scoring and comparing scores would become hopelessly complicated. For example, if the instructions of a multi-round exercise say that the negotiators must make their offers simultaneously and in sequence, without discussion, one round at a time, please do so. (It would violate the spirit of the exercise simply to present your counterpart with a signed list of offers for all 20 rounds, as a student once did). The class will function more effectively if we all cooperate in observing these rules. In class discussion, of course, suggestions for more creative resolutions are welcome. For most negotiations, you will need to turn in an outcome report. If you fail to reach an agreement by the deadline, you will be scored accordingly.

TECHNOLOGY POLICY:

Cell phones must be turned off for class.

Computers are not permitted during discussion unless otherwise specified. Research suggests that laptop use diminishes the learning of others around you. Moreover,

preliminary research supports the idea that hand-written note-taking results in superior performance than typing. If you would like to take notes on a digital device, you must let me know in advance, and use a lie-flat tablet or similar device (in airplane mode).

ATTENDANCE POLICY:

Due to the exercise and group-based format of this class, **in-person attendance is mandatory**. This class does not employ a hybrid format. You must be present in order to negotiate. **YOU CANNOT MISS ANY PART OF THE CLASS**

LATE ASSIGNMENT AND EXTENSION POLICY

I do not accept late assignments. They will receive a grade of zero. Or something not quite zero but **BAD BAD BAD**.

ACADEMIC HONESTY

You must be the sole author of work you submit in this course, excluding group work. **Plagiarism or cheating in an exam will result in a failing grade in the course and a referral to the Dean of Students' Office for further action.** I will not give credit to any assignment submitted in this class for which you have received credit in another course.

Please familiarize yourself with the UCSD Policy on Integrity and Scholarship if you are uncertain.

<https://senate.ucsd.edu/operating-procedures/senate-manual/appendices/2>

ACCOMODATIONS FOR STUDENTS WITH DISABILITIES (UCSD POLICY):

A student who has a disability or special need and requires an accommodation in order to have equal access to the classroom must register with the Office for Students with Disabilities (OSD). The OSD will determine what accommodations may be made and provide the necessary documentation to present to the faculty member. Please visit the OSD website for further information or contact the Office for Students with Disabilities by calling (858) 534-4382 or emailing osd@ucsd.edu. The student must present the OSD letter of certification and OSD accommodation recommendation to the appropriate faculty member to initiate the request for accommodation in classes, examinations, or other academic program activities. No accommodations can be implemented retroactively.

HEALTH AND WELL-BEING:

This class is not more important than your physical and psychological health and the well-being of you or your family. Many students deal with a range of challenging issues that can impact their learning, such as physical illness, housing or food insecurity, financial stress, strained relationships, loss of motivation, depression, anxiety, stress, or grief.

Below are several resources available to UC San Diego students:

UC San Diego Counseling and Psychological Services (UCSD CaPS)

(p) 858-534-3755 (available 24-7)

(w) <https://caps.ucsd.edu/>

UC San Diego Student Health Services

(p) 858-534-3300

(w) <https://studenthealth.ucsd.edu/>

UC San Diego Health Coaching

(w) <https://healthpromotion.ucsd.edu/services/health-coaching/index.html>

(e) hps@health.ucsd.edu

GRADING CRITERIA

Class Participation	50%
Final	50%

Participation in Classroom Activities

In the class discussions and debriefing sessions that will follow each negotiation exercise you will be asked to share information about the readings, results, strategies attempted, and reactions to the negotiation process. Quality contributions to the class are likely to possess one or more of the following properties:

- Offer a different, unique, but relevant, perspective based on analysis and theory
- Contribute to moving the discussion and analysis forward, not backwards
- Build upon the comments of your classmates
- Transcend the “I feel” syndrome; that is, include some evidence or logic
- Link relevant concepts to current events or past class discussions
- Concisely relate personal life experiences to the issue being discussed
- Clarification questions are allowed, but they might make me lose confidence in your preparation.

- The comment enhances the learning of the group as a whole.
- I need to see your hands up 30 times in every class.

My expectations are high. The class will be better if you hold yourself to that high standard. I will not lift you up. My goal is not to evaluate or to assess who's the best- it's to train all of you. If you feel hesitant to participate or that you do not have sufficient opportunity to participate, please let me know via email so I can facilitate your participation.